

The Bones of Joseph

Life and economics are the study of the same living spontaneous order.

Sage Clokey

Life is voluntary order guided by conscience, and everything that replaces conscience with control — whether at the cellular level or the political level — is the disease.

There are two ways things are made: top-down control — machines, factories, monoculture — and bottom-up emergence — biology, ecosystems, markets. Free markets mirror living systems. Central planning mirrors mechanical systems. This is not metaphor. It is measurable fact.

The E. coli gene regulatory network — 282 nodes, 308 edges — tolerates removal of 36.8% of its nodes before fragmenting. A centralized star graph collapses at 1.9%. That is a 19:1 robustness ratio in favor of the distributed architecture. The spiral is not just beautiful. It is measurably superior by an order of magnitude.

Adam Smith described the invisible hand of the market — a spontaneous order emerging from countless individuals making voluntary decisions with only local knowledge. The cell discovered it four billion years before anyone wrote it down.

I. The Price System Older Than Civilization

Mises argued that without prices, a central planner cannot rationally allocate resources. The cell proves him right.

Each enzyme prices its substrate through binding affinity. Each receptor prices its ligand through expression level. ATP emerged as the universal

biological currency the same way money emerges in Menger's theory — not by design, but because adenosine triphosphate happened to be the most exchangeable energy carrier, the most "saleable" metabolite, and every pathway that could use it gained a selective advantage. The cell runs a price system older than civilization.

In simulation, distributed metabolic allocation retains 71.1% of output under perturbation. Centralized allocation retains 53.0%. Even an omniscient linear program — flux balance analysis with a complete genome-scale model of 2,712 reactions and 1,516 genes — achieves only 70% accuracy on gene knockout predictions, because 30% of the knowledge exists only in the local state of each molecular agent and cannot be encoded in any central model.

This is Mises' calculation problem confirmed in metabolites.

And when that price system breaks — when a cell stops reading growth factor signals, ignores contact inhibition, overrides the feedback that says *stop* — you get cancer. Cancer is not a disease of bad parts. It is the destruction of the price system that coordinated voluntary exchange.

II. The Membrane Is the Property Line

Voluntaryism is written into how biology functions. Cells act by choice. They signal other cells, but they only react to those signals by choice. Every gene transfer, every vesicle received, every nanotube built requires both sides to participate. The membrane is the property line. The receptor is the customs agency. Nothing enters without consent.

The genome is the written law of the organism, and it does natural genetic engineering — moving toward the spiritual law of life through trial, feedback, and recombination. Selection isn't by death alone but by adaptation and distributed knowledge, by trial and error. Selection is the choice of how it recombines — and it's a choice, not just random. The living language of genetics emerges through spontaneous order — not

specific clone designs but choices and biodiversity. Don't design one thing. Design the possibilities so that it can adapt and grow and not be monoculturally weak.

III. Isolation Is the Disease

Empire cannot tolerate living systems. To control a system, you must first kill it. Living ecosystems are too complex, too adaptive, too uncontrollable. So empire clears them. Monoculture replaces biodiversity. Concrete replaces soil. Bureaucracy replaces wisdom.

There is no disease except the disease of isolation. Each isolated agent makes it less likely for there to be a way figured out on how to combat a problem. This is Hayek's knowledge problem made flesh.

The immune system's cell-to-cell communication network has a betweenness Gini coefficient of 0.000 — perfectly distributed, zero gatekeeping. Remove any single cell type and 75% of communication survives. No master cell. No central authority deciding which signals are permitted. Every agent you isolate is a node removed from that network. Each one carried local knowledge — immune experience, behavioral adaptation, signal processing that no other node possessed. The network doesn't just lose a participant. It loses what that participant would have discovered, shared, and contributed to the collective solution.

I knew this before I had the data.

During my first year at UC Santa Cruz, I was suspended for one year because I repeatedly refused to comply with the university's COVID-19 mask policy. From my perspective, the rule did not make sense, particularly in the dining halls. Students were expected to wear masks while walking inside, but once they sat down to eat, everyone removed their masks. Because of that, I chose not to wear a mask in the dining halls or elsewhere on campus.

On the last day of my first quarter, dining hall staff called the campus police because I was not wearing a mask. Rather than argue, I left that dining hall and went to another one, but I continued not to wear a mask. After the quarter ended, I was told I had to move off campus. I found housing off campus and continued attending classes while maintaining the same position on the mask policy. Later that quarter, one of my professors gave me a cookie before class and then asked me to put on a mask. To me, that felt contradictory. When I refused, the professor told me to leave the classroom. I stayed, and the professor grabbed my backpack before letting go and calling the campus police. When the officers arrived, I explained what had happened. My impression was that they personally thought it was a minor issue, even though they still had to respond to the call.

Over the following months, the matter proceeded through the university's disciplinary process. I was not immediately aware of the outcome. Near the end of the following quarter, when I attempted to register for summer classes, I discovered that I had been suspended for one year. Because of that suspension, I lost my ability to continue at UCSC and missed the spring quarter. I returned to San Luis Obispo and attended Cuesta College for about a year and a half. Looking back, I appreciate that period because it allowed me to spend more time with my family, especially my brother, before returning to continue my education. The part that has always stood out to me is the timing. Shortly before I left UCSC because of the suspension, the university lifted its mask mandate. From my perspective, I was ultimately suspended for violating a rule that was no longer in effect by the time the suspension began. That sequence of events has remained one of the main reasons I question how the policy and the disciplinary process were handled.

I broke those rules instinctually, and I have come to realize that my instinct was aligned with the way that immunity actually works. The immune system does not learn in quarantine. It learns through contact. Regulatory T cells develop tolerance by encountering antigens. Mucosal

immunity builds its library by sampling what comes through, not by sealing the border. Steve Cole at UCLA has shown that social isolation literally reprograms gene expression — upregulating inflammation, downregulating antiviral defense. The genome reads isolation as pathology. The lockdowns did at the population level exactly what Cole measured at the genomic level: isolation in, antiviral defense out.

What if the disease isn't the variants — what if it's you? Is an elephant diseased because it can't climb a tree? Looking at the living through a machine lens makes you believe that the thing that makes something work is the thing that is the problem. Variants are not diseases. The disease is when you don't help maintain what exists. Don't cut what grows. Maintain what grows. Allow what grows and guide it. Give it what it needs to continue in the way it is supposed to. Many pieces of diversity can thrive when given their strengths. Anything can be a disease in the wrong environment. It is better to study variants for what will help them thrive than to decide what is a disease and what is not. Disease is the central planning, not the variation. In the parable of Judges 9, the olive tree, the fig tree, and the vine each decline the crown because each has a purpose it cannot abandon without ceasing to be what it is. It is the thornbush — the plant with no fruit, no oil, no sweetness — that accepts the kingship. The thorn doing the work of a thorn is essential. The thorn trying to be a crown is catastrophic. The disease is the thorns stepping above instead of within.

Beware the ruler who cloaks themselves in the language of safety. For the predator always pretends to be the protector. Tyranny never arrives as a threat — it arrives as a friend. As a savior. As the one who just wants to keep you safe.

IV. The Living Order and the Dead One

The Living Age rests upon three complementary understandings. Black — economics: no worldly rulers, spontaneous order, freedom creates

coordination. Purple — theology: the true divine King, conscience guides moral responsibility, freedom is preserved while goodness is invited. Green — biology: living order, life continually adapts through distributed communication, living systems organize themselves.

These are not separate truths. Economics explains how free societies organize. Theology explains why conscience matters. Biology explains how living systems grow. Together they reveal one living principle: order emerges through distributed agents acting according to conscience rather than through centralized control.

There are two orders in this world, and there have always been two. One is the order of life — spontaneous, voluntary, free. The other is the order of control — imposed, mechanical, dead.

Nature does not grow in cubes. Trees do not branch in right angles. Shells do not expand in grids. Galaxies do not rotate in boxes. The Fibonacci spiral appears again and again because it is the geometry of efficient, decentralized growth. No central planner commands the spiral. Each part grows according to local information, and the whole emerges naturally. This is what Hayek called spontaneous order — the pattern that arises when distributed agents coordinate through local signals that no planner designed and no authority commands.

The machine is the opposite philosophy. It is creation forcing its will on creation. Machines are creation controlling creation. Life is Creator guiding creation. We can only act as agents of the Creator. We are not all-knowing beings.

V. The Kingdom of Conscience

The Kingdom of God is not of this world. It is written on the soul. It flows through the conscience. It is the Law that predates all kings, all flags, all papers, and all crowns. In this kingdom, no man is above another. Every

soul is accountable directly to God. There is no chain of command — only a divine current through the conscience.

Just as decentralized markets coordinate millions of independent decisions into an economic order, conscience coordinates the free actions of living beings into a moral order. There is another invisible hand. Conscience is the invisible hand of God.

America is not a specifically Christian nation. It is a nation of conscience no matter the religion. Faith isn't in the specific story or the specific text or scripture — it is in man's relationship to its Creator, choosing to do what is right. All written law is a guess at the law written on our heart. Do not follow the written law blindly — follow your conscience. It is every man's obligation to choose to do what is right, not to follow their leaders, because their leader could be wrong and it is your job to help them keep the right path by always choosing to do what is right.

There is a higher order than the written order — the unwritten spiritual order that we must all move towards the best we can. The only way to achieve it is to all act as distributed agents, not a hierarchy of chain of command. The kingdom of conscience is one big distributed decentralized game of Wordle.

Laws cannot be made — they can only be discovered by the local distributed knowledge of conscience of the people. The true power is not in the capitals but in the minds of people who think freely according to conscience. Those who seek power over others control how truth is portrayed, tearing good people down with compromise in order to get through the gate they control. Their gate is crumbling. People are finding that the gate has no fence to stop them from going around it entirely.

VI. The Bones of Joseph

There is an eternal battle against the blocks — a hidden war fought not with weapons that kill, but with weapons that resurrect.

The blue flame is the inheritance — the call to action, the fight against darkness, the warrior's path, the duty received. The red flame is the fall — the turn into coercion, the forcing of will, the empire, every worldly kingdom that demanded obedience and called it order. The green flame is the return — built by the one who learned that victory is not through power but through surrender. The green flame raises the light. It is wisdom over aggression, guardian over warrior. The break of the blue gives rise to the created green of pure light. The green flame brings new life to the dead.

In the spiral of names, the fire is passed. My grandfather, Art Clokey, created Gumby — the hero of possibility, a being who could become any form, enter any world, and never be confined by rigid shape. Gumby was not entertainment. Gumby was prophecy — the story of life versus the machine, the spiral against the block.

My father, Joe Clokey, continued this mission. He and my grandfather made the Davey and Goliath Christmas special — a story about a Christian, a Muslim, and a Jew getting along over the winter holidays. Many religions, one faith. After that film, every door closed on him. He was strung along for years in exclusive deals that led nowhere. My parents split up. Fourteen years later, he died of a brain bleed at the age of 56.

The Living Age is not about one character or one company. It is about a way of seeing. Living things are not machines. Living systems grow through communication, relationship, adaptation, stewardship, and creativity. The task is not merely to preserve old creations. The task is to continue creating. That is the work of every generation.

Arthur Clokey told the living spiral through stop motion. Joseph Clokey preserved the flame through the darkness until it took him. My father was cremated. The bones of Joseph have returned to the dust. The green flame is the return.

Every age builds new thrones. They promise order. They demand allegiance. They tremble when questioned. But all earthly kingdoms fall — not because they are weak, but because they are not real.

For dust you are, and to dust you shall return. The kingdoms of this world rise and fall. Their rulers return to the earth, and their plans perish. Yet the Kingdom of Heaven does not perish. It is not sustained by earthly power but by faithfulness to God. Wherever conscience is aligned with God's will, there the hope of Zion endures. Before he died, the patriarch Joseph made the Israelites swear an oath to carry his bones when God delivered them. The bones of Joseph returned to the dust, as all flesh does. But the promise God made did not return to the dust.

"Put not your trust in princes, nor in the son of man, in whom there is no help. His breath goeth forth, he returneth to his earth; in that very day his thoughts perish." (Psalm 146:3-4, KJV)

The work of agents of God never dies because God is eternal. The vessels of God's plans may perish but there will always be another to carry the torch. Conscience is a property of living systems — the invisible hand of God that guides living systems toward God's concept of a plan while maintaining the free will of the living.

Worldly kingdoms return to the dust. The Kingdom of Heaven endures in the conscience of those who seek God and walk in His ways.

Being pushed out is not the end — it is the beginning. Where God is King, order grows. Where men claim the throne, order must be enforced.

Surrender to God, so you never kneel to man.